

Community Heroes

What makes someone a community hero?

Grade

K-2

Subjects

ELA, Social Studies

Estimated Duration

15-19 instructional
hours

Key Content

community, heroes,
portraits,
informational text,
explanatory writing



Students learn about well-known historical and present-day heroes, and identify and discuss heroes in their local community. They work together as a class to develop a shared definition and understanding of the

characteristics of a hero. Students each focus on one community hero, create an artistic portrait of that person, and write a paragraph caption explaining who the hero is and how they contribute to their community for display in a “Gallery of Heroes” exhibit (<https://my.pblworks.org/node/12445>) and for presenting to visitors who attend the exhibition opening. (Read a related article. (<https://www.pblworks.org/blog/student-voice-and-choice-elementary-grades>))

Project Path

Project Launch

What is a hero?

Entry event: Draw, share and discuss a picture of a hero and explore stories highlighting heroes.

Build Knowledge and Develop & Critique

Who are some famous heroes from history and the present day?

Develop shared criteria for what defines a hero after reading and discussing books about well-known historical and present-day figures and engaging in learning centers to learn about a variety of heroes.

Who are the heroes in our community?

Revise and refine the class definition and characteristics of a hero and identify, discuss, and write about examples of heroes in their lives and local communities.

What can we create to teach others about heroes in our community?

Create a portrait and write a paragraph about their selected hero's contribution to the community.

Form teams and rehearse presentations for gallery opening.

Present Products

How can we share our tributes with others?

Host a “Gallery of Heroes” exhibition opening to honor and celebrate community heroes and to inform guests about the heroes in the gallery.

Make It Yours

Reflect on your students

- How are your students and their families engaged in making the community better? What connections can you make between these activities and the actions taken by the well-known historical figures you are studying?
- How can you provide examples of heroes from a wide range of cultural backgrounds, including those represented by the students in your classroom?
- How might you use this project to inspire students to take action and become community heroes themselves?

Reflect on your context

- What local historical or contemporary change-makers might you highlight or introduce to students as part of this project?
- What local institution (e.g., library, museum, community center, town hall) might serve as a good site for the student exhibition? Who might serve as a public audience?

Reflect on the content & skills

- How will you identify and select the texts that students will explore during this project? Can you partner with your school or local librarian?
- What scaffolds and supports will students need to engage with these texts and develop their written products?
- How will you structure class discussions about community heroes so that all students are able to engage?

Take It Further

Here are some ideas for expanding this project if you choose to do so:

- As part of the entry event, have students watch and discuss one or more of the following:
 - the music video for Carrie Underwood's The Champion (<https://youtu.be/HgknAaKNaMM>) (3:45)
 - Kid President Talks to Tom Hanks About Heroes! (<https://youtu.be/Zkn9FOWWf20>) (4:50)
 - For the Heroes: A Pep Talk From Kid President (<https://youtu.be/tgF1Enrgo2g>) (4:15)
- If the project is scheduled during a traditional celebration time period such as Women's History Month (March) or American Indian Heritage Month (November), make that a focus for student learning and research. See Heritage and History Months (<https://www.state.gov/state-department-celebrates-heritage-and-history-months/>) listed the U.S. Department of State website as well as International Days and Weeks (<https://www.un.org/en/observances/list-days-weeks>) listed on the United Nations website.
- Check with your local history museum to see which well-known people are featured there. Visit the museum for field research or have someone from the museum come in to talk to the class.
- Create a display or special section of your classroom library dedicated to heroes. Ask your school librarian to select books and other resources on this topic that are appropriate for learners at your grade level.
- To incorporate informational writing, have students create hero journals in which they record information about each of the heroes you are studying together.
- Incorporate books and lessons about people who make a difference into your daily reading instruction and/or social-emotional learning curriculum.
- If you use a specific social-emotional learning or character education curriculum, have students identify which character traits each well-known hero demonstrated and have them explain their reasoning.
- Invite a print or TV reporter to visit the class (in-person or via video conference) as a guest speaker (<https://my.pblworks.org/resource/working-outside-experts>) to share stories about community heroes they have met in their work. Have the reporter talk about what the hero did to help others and why. Ask the reporter to reflect on the characteristics they consider to be heroic and share some of their own personal heroes.
- Collaborate with your school's art teacher or other art professional to support students in the process of creating their community hero portraits. If your school does not have an

art teacher, contact your local Arts Council for recommendations. Museums often have education programs that offer outreach to support art in the classroom as well.

- If time and materials allow, offer students a choice of artistic media and process so that the finished products are more varied.
- Have students gain valuable field experience by visiting a museum to see portraits and how they are displayed. If time and resources are a challenge, remember that many museums offer virtual tours.
- With your guidance, have students connect with the heroes they have selected to interview them (<https://my.pblworks.org/resource/preparing-interviews>). Students can take their photographs as inspiration for their portraits and/or gather more information for their paragraphs.
- As a technological extension and/or alternative to writing a paragraph, have students record details about their community hero using an app such as Flipgrid (<https://info.flipgrid.com/>) or SeeSaw (<https://web.seesaw.me/>).
- When students are preparing to present their work in the gallery, have older students come in and play the role of guests.
- Host the student exhibition in a public setting such as a local library, museum, community center, or town hall.
- Set up a display in the gallery space to share artifacts from the project such as books students read, student writing samples, etc. to help guests better understand the work that happened throughout the project.
- Have students dress up for the event or wear a specific color to help identify them as a member of the class.
- Provide refreshments to contribute to the celebratory feel of the event.

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